

1880–1888

THE RISE AND FALL OF THE BUSTLE

By 1880 there was no discernible bustle, and fishtail trains were rejected. Cotton combinations – chemise and drawers – were worn under the main outfit, and were supplemented by knitted woollen combination garments that combated a series of cold winters. An extremely tight, steel-boned corset secured the small waist that was being increasingly admired and forced a rigid, upright posture. Further boning reinforced the dress bodice. A new bustle shape gradually developed from 1881–83, this time stiff and angular. From 1883–87 the bustle grew, and stuck out at right angles, eventually tilting over into a chicken tail feather flourish before disappearing. The majority of garments were now made by sewing machine, and many fabrics were coloured with synthetic dyes.

MOURNING



Half-mourning cap



Mourning bonnet

There was a strict etiquette for mourning royalty and relatives. The fashion industry perfected the art of dyeing fabric black, providing copious lengths of black crêpe and bombazine fabrics, ribbons, bonnets, veils, and feathers. Department stores stocked ready-to-wear mourning outfits. Woollen cloth was advised as it absorbed light, rather than reflecting it. Half-mourning required grey, white, and purple to be worn in specific time frames.



Victorian mourning dress

Spanish promenade fashion

Contrasting silks and velvets, wools and silks, or light and dark colours were used effectively in exciting combinations, and matching accessories created a smart ensemble. Deportment – a back as straight as a rod – was key to carrying off this style.

False waistcoat fronts

1888



Stiff collar

Balayouse dust ruffle visible

Coordinating bonnet

Triple-layered cape collar

1880

Matching parasol with pom-poms

Fan pleating

French day dress This walking outfit demonstrates superb use of controlled skirt drapery and contrasting trimmings: a neat row of buttons, collar with alternating colours, and discrete fan pleating on the cuffs and hem.

Deep-dyed colours fashionable across Europe

Long bodice front

Feathered cap tied under chin

Pomegranate motif

Morning dress The pomegranate design on this skirt is particularly identified with Spain. Eiderdown feather petticoats were popular in the cold winter of 1887–88.